**Key question**
Why did the USA put more pressure on Israel to make peace with the PLO in the early 1990s?

## The Iraqi invasion of Kuwait 1990

**Key date**
Iraqi invasion of Kuwait: 1990

The Americans were still determined to bring Israelis and Palestinians face to face at the negotiating table but, before any peace talks could be started, another conflict in the Middle East grabbed the headlines. In August 1990, Iraqi troops invaded Kuwait, a neighbouring Arab state, claiming that Kuwait belonged to them (see the map on page 112). Most of the Arab world, as well as other countries, condemned the Iraqi attack. The USA rushed troops to the Middle East. The UN called for Iraq to withdraw and the Americans led a huge multinational force which, by the end of February 1991, had driven the Iraqis out of Kuwait. This was known as the Gulf War, because Kuwait is on the Persian Gulf. It is explained more fully in Chapter 8.

Palestinians and other Arabs were quick to point out what they saw as the USA's double standards. They said that the Americans had acted swiftly to enforce the UN demand for Iraq to withdraw from Kuwait, yet they had not managed, even after 20 years, to persuade Israel to withdraw its troops from the occupied territories of Gaza and the West Bank. The UN had demanded this as far back as 1967 in the famous Resolution 242 (see page 53). The US government was stung by this criticism. It wanted to keep the support of Arab states such as Egypt, Saudi Arabia, even Syria, who had joined the USA in the fight against Iraq. Also, America's allies in the West depended on imports of oil from Arab states. So the US government was at last willing to put more pressure on Israel. It was also in a better position to do so now.

### The end of the Cold War

The reason for this change was that the Cold War (between the USA and the Soviet Union) had now ended. The communist government in Russia was, by this time, collapsing. It could no longer support the Arab states so strongly. In fact, Russia was now desperately seeking US financial aid. Therefore, the US government could expect the co-operation not only of the Russians but also of Arab leaders who would no longer be able to rely on Russia for arms and money. All of this meant that the USA did not have to support Israel *in order to* contain a Russian threat in the Middle East any longer. The US government could therefore push the Israelis into making peace. In September 1991, the US President threatened to withhold $10 billion of loans to Israel. This threat had the desired effect.

## The Madrid conference 1991

In October 1991, the US government persuaded the Israelis to hold face-to-face talks with Palestinian leaders. By now, an increasing number of both Israelis and Palestinians were coming to the conclusion that they had more to gain from making peace than making war. At the talks held in Madrid in Spain, the Palestinians spoke of the need for compromise but the Israeli leader, Yitzhak Shamir, was still intransigent and little progress